Township of NIPISSING
"Life the way it should be" ESTABLISHED 1888

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Township of Nipissing
Report to Council

Subject: Lake Nipissing Water Levels and 2026 Spring Outlook
Date: March 17, 2026
Prepared by: SNF Committee Representative
Attendance: Dave Yemm, Tom Piper, and John-Paul Negrinotti

Purpose

The purpose of this report is to provide Council with a summary of the recent update provided by Public Services and Procurement Canada (PSPC) and the Sturgeon–Nipissing–French (SNF) Water Management Committee regarding Lake Nipissing water levels, recent conditions, and the outlook for the upcoming 2026 spring freshet.

Summary of 2025 Water Conditions

The 2025 spring freshet experienced two distinct peak inflow periods. The first occurred in mid-March due to warm temperatures and rainfall which initiated early snowmelt. A second, larger peak occurred toward the end of April as temperatures increased again and additional precipitation occurred. Overall, the snowpack entering the freshet period was close to average.

During this time, dam operators managed discharge from Lake Nipissing carefully to balance inflows while minimizing downstream flooding impacts along the French River system. Discharge levels were progressively increased through April as inflows rose, with peak discharge reaching approximately **380 cubic metres per second (m^3/s)**. Despite the high flows, operators were able to keep the French River near, but generally within, historical flood thresholds.

Following the freshet, summer conditions were relatively stable. Early summer precipitation was slightly above average; however, August experienced significantly drier conditions with rainfall totals well below normal. As a result, lake levels declined through the late summer period and briefly fell below the minimum navigation level in early August.

Fall 2025 Conditions

The fall period saw a significant precipitation deficit, with approximately **150 mm less rainfall than average** between August and mid-October. These dry conditions required careful management of lake outflows to conserve water storage heading into the winter season. The fall drawdown of Lake Nipissing occurred later than usual as operators attempted to balance storage levels while maintaining downstream flows.

Current Lake Operations

Lake Nipissing is currently in its annual winter drawdown period. Water levels are gradually being lowered through dam operations along the French River until approximately **April 1**, at which time the dam gates are closed to allow the lake to refill during the spring freshet and return to normal seasonal operating levels.

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At the time of writing this report, the overall trend indicates that lake levels are beginning to rise, with approximately **200 m³/s** of water currently passing through the **Dry Pine Bay** monitoring location. The average water level on Lake Nipissing was measured at **194.67 metres** as of midnight on March 9, 2026.

The watershed is presently under a **Watershed Conditions Statement – Water Safety / Flood Outlook**. The next escalation stage would be a Flood Watch (potential flooding), followed by the highest level, a Flood Warning (flooding imminent or already occurring).

Current Conditions and 2026 Spring Outlook

Heading into the 2026 spring season, water management planning is focused on several key factors that will influence lake levels and potential flooding risk:

- Snowpack accumulation across the watershed
- Spring rainfall amounts
- Temperature trends affecting the rate of snowmelt
- Base flows entering the lake system

At this time, there remains uncertainty regarding the magnitude of the upcoming spring freshet. Water managers must balance two competing risks:

1. **Potential spring flooding** if rapid snowmelt and heavy rainfall occur; and
2. **The possibility of the lake not fully refilling** if the dry conditions experienced in fall 2025 continue into the spring.

Improvements to Water Management

Several improvements to forecasting and monitoring systems have recently been completed to assist with water management decisions, including updated operational guidelines for the Lake Nipissing–French River system, an improved inflow forecasting model, additional hydrometric monitoring stations, automated snow and weather monitoring stations, and improved public information through the **PSPC French River dams website**.

Conclusion

Water levels on Lake Nipissing are closely managed through the SNF Water Management Committee and dam operations along the French River. While last year's conditions included both high spring inflows and very dry late-season conditions, the outlook for 2026 remains dependent on snowpack, precipitation, and spring temperatures. Monitoring will continue throughout the spring freshet period, and further updates will be provided to Council as conditions evolve.

John-Paul Negrinotti
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